A SUMMARY OF THE ENTIRE HILCHOT SHABBAT IN 14 CLASSES

Cleaning and Knots: Melaben, Kosher and Matir

Class 9 of 14

Series: Laws of Shabbat — a 14-part course

Shiur: 9 of 14

Topic: Melaben (Cleaning and Laundering) and Kosher/Matir (Tying and Untying)

Recorded: Tiferet Eyal, Hendon — 22 January 2019 (a snowy night)

Schedule note: The course was now about a lecture behind; trapping, slaughtering, sewing and tearing moved to the next shiur (5 February).

Recap

Last week: **Gozez** — cutting hair and nails, combing — and **Sove'a** — no dyeing with food and drink, make-up, sunbathing, toilet colouring blocks.

Part A — Melaben (Cleaning)

Definition

In the Mishkan, sheared wool had to be **cleaned** before it could be spun. Melaben is cleaning the **fabric itself** — removing something absorbed into the material. Removing something sitting on the **surface** (e.g. feathers all over your clothes) is not cleaning — permitted.

Three stages — each a separate Torah prohibition

1. **Soaking** in water — begins releasing the dirt.
2. **Scrubbing** — dislodges it.
3. **Squeezing out** the water.

Even if two stages happened before Shabbat or by themselves, the third is still forbidden. So: don't run the tap onto a dirty shirt in the sink; don't put water on a stain; if rain fell on a stain, don't scrub it; don't wring out a wet garment.

Soaking a clean garment

Some Rishonim hold that soaking even a clean garment adds cleanliness. **Halacha: soaking a clean garment is permitted.**

- A **clean towel** may be soaked to cool a headache.
- A **clean towel** may be used to wipe up spilt water — but not a **dirty** (soiled) one.
- Don't saturate it so much that lifting it inevitably squeezes water out — use another towel; a soaked towel is also a concern because one might come to wring it out.

- **Paper towels/tissues** may be soaked completely and thrown away — but don't squeeze them while lifting.

Coloured spills

As discussed last week, a bleeding finger may be wrapped in a white towel (better to rinse under the tap first, but strictly permitted). For red juice or wine spills, **prefer paper tissues** to a reusable towel or handkerchief — disposables raise no colouring question. With no alternative, a towel may be used.

Removing a stain without water

Dried mud on clothes: is scraping it off Tochen (grinding)? One opinion says no — earth was already "ground" (*ein tochen achar tochen*, like crumbling a biscuit) — but we don't rely on that. Rather:

- Removing what is **on top** of the fabric with a fingernail — permitted by all.
- The **stain** remaining in the fabric — preferably ask a **non-Jew** to scrape it with a nail. If none is available and you need to look presentable in public, there is room to scrape it yourself.
- **Never with water** — and you may not ask a non-Jew to use water (a Torah prohibition), except in extreme circumstances.
- **Dry mud on shoes** may likewise be scraped off — wet mud is a different matter.

Dust on clothes

A hat, jacket or dress that fell on a dusty floor: for Sephardim, dust sits on the surface, so one may **shake or brush it off** — even with a clothes brush. Since one view (followed by Ashkenazim) considers it a Torah prohibition, preferably do it with a **shinui**, e.g. the left hand. Brushing a hat is fine.

Spreading out wet clothes

Chazal forbade **spreading out** wet clothes to dry — because of **mar'it ayin** (onlookers may think you washed them on Shabbat) — and **mar'it ayin applies even in private** (*afilu bechadrei chadarim asur*). So no spreading on a banister, airer or washing line, even indoors.

- **Clipping** a garment with one peg so it just **hangs down** is not "spreading" — permitted (a peg is a *kli shemelachto le'issur*, usable for a permitted purpose). Two pegs spreading it out is a problem.
- Hanging a wet coat in its **usual place**, e.g. on a coat hook or hanger — fine.
- A jacket over the back of a chair, as normal — fine; spreading a dress over a chair — not.
- Wet socks — you can't spread them out to dry; keep them on, or borrow dry ones.

Wet items on a radiator — a Torah prohibition

Placing something **wet next to a heat source** is forbidden by the Torah: **Bishul** (heating the water) and **Melaben** (heat-drying is part of laundering). A heated towel rail may keep a **dry** towel warm — but don't dry your hands on it and hang it back, and never put a wet tea towel on a radiator.

Q: A hat dropped in the dirt and blown about by the wind? — You may brush it off; that is not a "growing" (Zore'a) issue.

Part B — Kosher and Matir (Tying and Untying)

Background

In the Mishkan, the *techelet* dye came from the *chilazon* (whether we have it today is debated — hence some wear tzitzit with blue threads); catching it required **nets**, made by knotting cords. Spools of thread were also knotted end to end.

Two views of what a Torah-level knot is

All agree a Torah-level knot must be **permanent** (*kayama*). The debate is whether it must also be a **professional/craftsman's knot** (like the Mishnah's sailors' and camel-drivers' knots):

View	Torah prohibition	Rabbinic prohibition	Practical rule
Rif, Rambam, Shulchan Aruch — Sephardim	Permanent and professional	Either one alone	An ordinary knot meant to be untied **within 7 days** is permitted; a professional knot is forbidden even for an hour
Rashi, Rosh, Rema — Ashkenazim	Permanent, even if not professional	Any knot meant to last a while	A knot must be meant to be untied **within 24 hours**

Shoelaces

- Sephardim may tie shoelaces intending to untie them within a week — e.g. on Shavuot night, staying up for more than 24 hours.
- Those who tie shoes once and then slip them on and off for weeks must never tie that first knot on Shabbat.

Double knots

The **Rema** treats a double knot as a craftsman's knot (Ashkenazim avoid it even for an hour). The **Chida** (Rav Chaim Yosef David Azulai), who travelled widely, records the custom in all Sephardi lands: a double knot is **not** professional. So Sephardim may tie a **double knot** to be untied within seven days — shoelaces, a woman's headscarf, the bands of a **Sefer Torah** (the Spanish and Portuguese custom). Even a Yom Tov Sefer Torah, which may not be opened again for months, may be tied with a double knot — a special case with its own reasoning.

A bow is not a knot

A bow (*aniva*) slips undone with a pull — not a knot at all, and may be tied even for the long term. A **tie** (necktie) is also an *aniva* and may be tied on Shabbat even if kept tied for weeks. (Shoelaces are a single knot plus a bow.)

Knots that are normally permanent

Intending to untie within a week doesn't help for knots that are **by nature permanent**:

- **Tzitzit** that have come undone — may not be re-tied, even "temporarily". Even **tightening** a loose tzitzit knot is making a knot — possibly a Torah prohibition.

- A broken **eruv** cord — may not be re-tied by a Jew; here one may ask a non-Jew.

Dustbin bags

Permanence counts even if you get no benefit from it: a double knot on a bin bag will stay tied for good. Use a **simple single knot** (one twist of the two ends), which has no permanence at all. Q: two single knots, one on each pair of corners? — each is just a single knot: fine.

Beware the overhand knot: a knot tied within one strand locks on itself — it has the status of a double knot (only if untied within seven days).

Untying

The same rules apply in reverse: one may untie any knot that is not professional and was not made to last more than seven days.

Q: Taking the bins out on Shabbat? — Raises carrying and muktseh questions; possible in certain circumstances — to be discussed in the Muktseh shiur.

Summary

- **Melaben** = cleaning the fabric itself. Soaking, scrubbing and wringing are each forbidden. Clean towels may be wetted; prefer paper for coloured spills.
- Surface dirt may be removed; a dry stain preferably by a non-Jew with a fingernail — never with water. Dust may be shaken or brushed off (ideally with a shinui).
- Don't spread wet clothes out to dry, even privately; hanging from one peg or in the normal place is fine. **Nothing wet on a radiator or heated rail.**
- **Knots (Sephardim):** any non-professional knot — single or double — to be untied within 7 days; bows and neckties always fine. Never re-tie or tighten tzitzit; bin bags with a simple single knot.

Coming Up

Break next week. **Shiur 10 — 5 February:**

- **Trapping** — pets, birds flying in, mousetraps; putting a baby in a cot; returning an escaped prisoner
- **Slaughtering** — flies in the house, infested vegetables, fly spray
- **Tearing** — envelopes and packaging

B'Ezrat Hashem

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